

# Ropes & Gray

A \$3.7 billion firm that refused to be full-service. What it actually does, how it makes money, what genuinely sets it apart – and why it is a relationship business before it is a law firm.

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- |    |                                                                                                                              |
|----|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 01 | It does not win deals. It wins <b>sponsors</b> – then earns from one relationship for a decade, across five practice groups. |
|----|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
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- |    |                                                                                                                                                  |
|----|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 02 | It is top-tier on <b>both sides</b> of a wall most firms only stand on one side of: private funds and registered funds. The wall is coming down. |
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- |    |                                                                                                                                               |
|----|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 03 | It hired a client's general counsel; a former head of its London office left to join a client. <b>Adviser and client are one talent pool.</b> |
|----|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
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## HOW TO USE THIS

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## SECTION 01

## A vertical firm, not a full-service one

|                                                                |                                                           |                                                           |
|----------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>\$3.7bn</b><br>Global revenue, FY2025<br>+9.4% YoY · £2.7bn | <b>\$7.04m</b><br>Profit per equity partner<br>≈ £5.2m    | <b>\$2.5m</b><br>Revenue per lawyer<br>+8.3% YoY          |
| <b>~1,500</b><br>Lawyers globally<br>~300 partners             | <b>16</b><br>Offices in 10 countries<br>London since 2010 | <b>15</b><br>London training contracts a year<br>NQ £170k |

Ropes & Gray began in Boston in 1865 and spent most of its life as a well-regarded regional firm with one unusual asset: it was counsel to the fund complexes that grew up around Boston's money-management industry. That accident of geography became the strategy.

The firm never tried to become a global generalist. It made a narrower bet – own the **private capital** economy (the sponsors, their funds, their deals, their portfolio companies, their exits) and own **healthcare and life sciences** as the sector where that capital is most concentrated and most heavily regulated. Everything else in the firm exists to serve those two.

That is why the comparison set is Kirkland & Ellis and Latham & Watkins rather than the Magic Circle. A Magic Circle firm sells breadth: it will do your bond issue, your competition defence and your shipping dispute. Ropes sells depth in one lane and prices accordingly.

### THE NUMBER THAT SHOWS THE STRATEGY

Revenue per lawyer of roughly **\$2.5 million**. That figure is what deliberate concentration looks like on a profit and loss account: high-value mandates, relatively few lawyers, no volume business. It is a more revealing statistic than the headline revenue, and almost no applicant will mention it.

London opened in 2010 on Ludgate Hill and is now the firm's second centre of gravity – described internally as the hub of a European private capital platform, not as a European full-service firm. London, Paris, Milan and Dublin are run as one European unit.

SECTION 02

# Governance above a matrix

An elected Chair and a Management Committee sit above a matrix: practice groups run down, geographies run across, and industry teams cut through both. A mandate is not handed to a department — it pulls specialists out of five or six rows at once.

GOVERNANCE



PRACTICE GROUPS × GEOGRAPHY

|                              | AMERICAS | EUROPE<br>London · Paris · Milan · Dublin | ASIA |
|------------------------------|----------|-------------------------------------------|------|
| Private capital & M&A        | ●        | ●                                         | ●    |
| Asset management & funds     | ●        | ●                                         | ●    |
| Finance & restructuring      | ●        | ●                                         | ●    |
| Tax · antitrust · regulatory | ●        | ●                                         | ●    |
| Litigation & enforcement     | ●        | ●                                         | ●    |

INDUSTRY TEAMS CUT ACROSS EVERY ROW

Healthcare & life sciences      Technology      Financial services      Infrastructure      Consumer

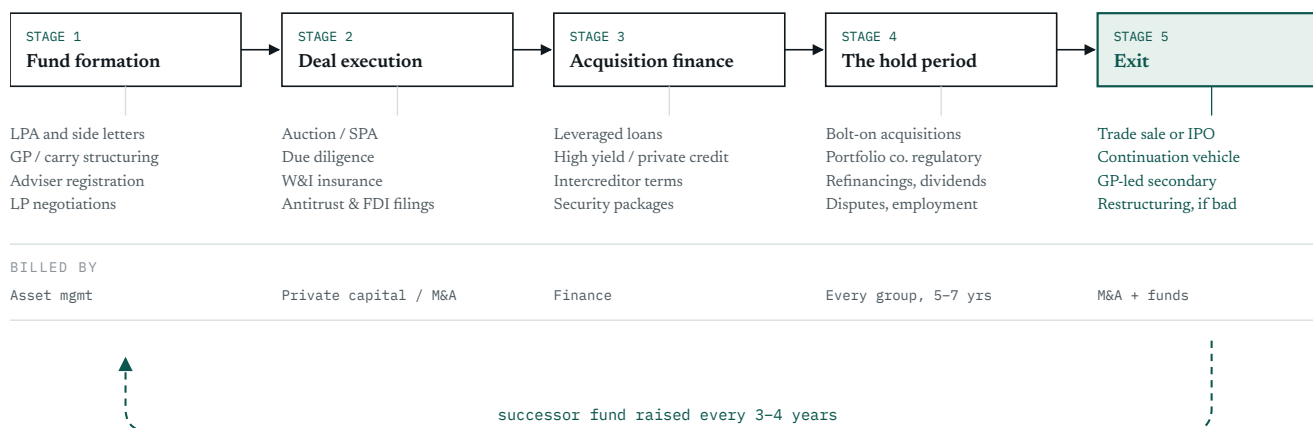
**Firms tell you their strategy through who they promote.** The vice chair, elected in 2024 for a term beginning January 2025, was previously co-head of the global private equity practice. The people setting firm strategy have sponsor-side instincts.

## SECTION 03

## How the firm actually makes money

The naive answer is "hourly rates on big deals". The real answer is that Ropes engineered its client base so a single sponsor relationship produces fees continuously for a decade, across five practice groups, whether or not the market is doing deals.

ONE SPONSOR CLIENT – BAIN CAPITAL, TPG, EQT, PARTNERS GROUP



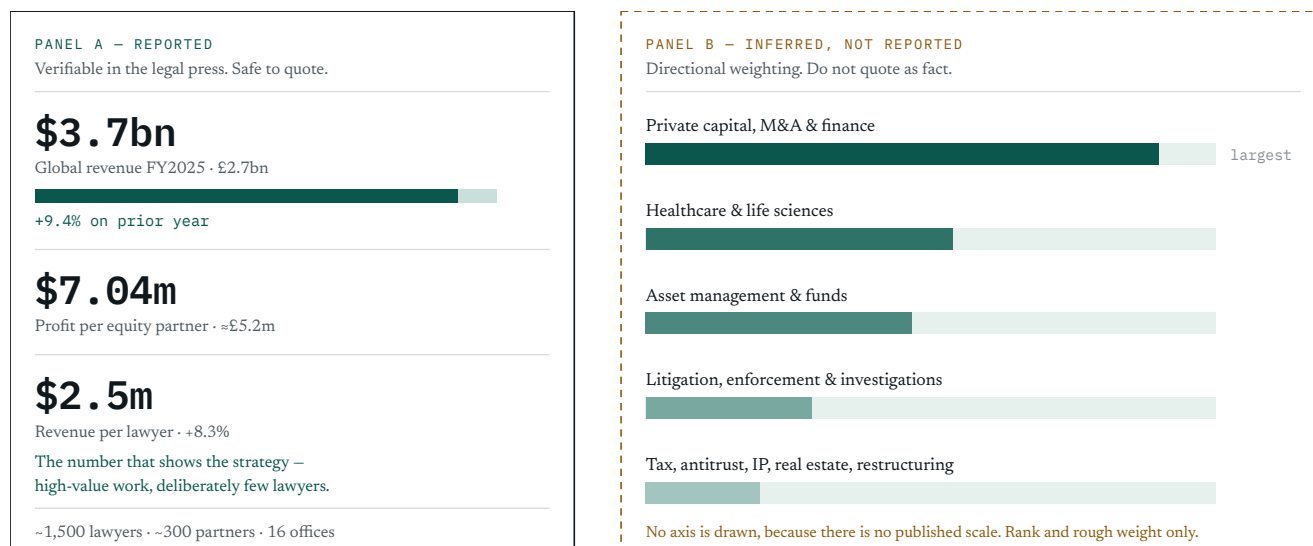
**Win the sponsor once and you are not on a deal – you are on an annuity that renews every vintage.**

**Note stage 5.** When trade sales and IPOs slow, as they did through 2023–24, the exit fee does not disappear – it migrates to continuation vehicles and GP-led secondaries. A firm strong in both is hedged against the M&A cycle in a way a pure M&A shop is not. This is the single most useful thing to understand about Ropes.

## SECTION 04

## Where the \$3.7 billion comes from

Ropes is a private partnership. It reports a top-line revenue figure and a profit-per-equity-partner figure to the legal press, and nothing else. It does **not** publish a practice-by-practice revenue breakdown, and neither does any comparable firm.



**Report what is reported.** You will find websites claiming precise splits such as "45% private equity, 25% life sciences". Those figures are not sourced to the firm. Quoting an invented statistic to a partner who knows the real number is the worst outcome available to you in an interview.

### SAY THIS INSTEAD

*"Ropes doesn't publish a practice split, but revenue per lawyer of around \$2.5 million tells you it's running a concentrated, high-value model rather than a volume one."* That is defensible, and it quietly signals that you understand what firms do and don't disclose.

## SECTION 05

## Where they are genuinely first-rank

Every firm claims every practice. These are the four where Ropes is at or near the top of the market, with the evidence attached.

## PILLAR ONE

### Private capital

- Buyouts, growth equity, take-privates
- Fund formation across buyout, credit, infrastructure and real assets
- Acquisition financing and private credit
- Clients include Bain Capital, TPG, Partners Group, EQT
- Private Capital Team of the Year, The Lawyer Awards 2026

## PILLAR TWO

### Secondaries

- Ranked #1 in Secondaries Investor's law firm survey
- Acts for 10 of the top 15 global secondaries buyers
- 600+ secondaries transactions in 2025 alone
- Continuation vehicles, GP-leds, LP portfolio sales, GP stakes
- The practice that made the firm cycle-resistant

## PILLAR THREE

### Registered funds

- Regular counsel to 2,000+ mutual funds, or their independent trustees
- Mutual funds, ETFs, closed-end, interval and tender-offer funds
- Fund counsel to PIMCO on 22 closed-end funds
- Jackson National multi-asset interval funds
- Section 36(b) fee litigation and SEC regulation

## PILLAR FOUR

### Healthcare & life sciences

- A sector vertical, not a side practice
- Biotech licensing and royalty monetisation
- FDA and MHRA regulatory work
- Healthcare buyouts and provider consolidation
- Hired a Chambers Band 1 life sciences regulatory partner into London, July 2026

## WHY THE FOUR SIT TOGETHER

They are not four businesses; they are one. A sponsor raises a fund (pillar one), buys a healthcare asset that needs regulatory expertise to underwrite properly (pillar four), and eventually exits it into a continuation vehicle (pillar two) – while the same firm advises the registered-fund managers now buying into private assets (pillar three). Each pillar makes the others more valuable. That is what a genuinely integrated firm looks like, as opposed to one that has simply collected practices.

## SECTION 06 • THE DEAL BOOK

## Headline buyouts and take-privates

The firm was named **Law360's Private Equity Group of the Year for 2025**. What follows is the evidence for that, grouped by what the work actually is rather than by size. Values are as reported at announcement.

| MATTER                                                                                   | VALUE                  | CLIENT / ROLE                                                 | WHAT IT TELLS YOU                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Hologic take-private</b><br>Announced Oct 2025 · closing H1 2026                      | \$18.3bn               | Blackstone and TPG — as healthcare and FDA regulatory counsel | Note the <i>role</i> . Ropes was not lead M&A counsel; it was brought in for regulatory expertise on a medical device business. That is the sector vertical being sold separately from the transactional practice — and it is how a firm gets onto a deal it did not originate. |
| <b>Toshiba Memory / Kioxia</b><br>2018                                                   | ~\$18bn                | Bain Capital-led consortium; team led from Tokyo              | Asia's largest-ever leveraged buyout at the time, and among the most complex PE-backed deals ever done in the region. See page 11 — this asset also produced the exit.                                                                                                          |
| <b>EQT / Nord Anglia Education</b>                                                       | \$14.5bn               | EQT                                                           | International schools group. A large-cap European sponsor deal for the client the firm has since hired a general counsel from.                                                                                                                                                  |
| <b>Madison Dearborn / NFP sale to Aon</b>                                                | \$13.4bn               | The sponsor and its portfolio company                         | A textbook exit to a strategic buyer, acting for both sponsor and asset — two mandates from one relationship.                                                                                                                                                                   |
| <b>New Mountain Capital programme</b><br>Including the formation of Smarter Technologies | \$18bn of transactions | New Mountain Capital                                          | Not one deal — a programme. Building a healthcare revenue-management platform out of multiple acquisitions is exactly the "hold period" work on page 5, and it is where the recurring fees live.                                                                                |
| <b>Select Medical take-private</b><br>March 2026                                         | \$3.9bn                | Welsh, Carson, Anderson & Stowe, leading a consortium         | Healthcare services take-private. Consortium deals need someone to referee between sponsors — a role that goes to the firm all sides trust.                                                                                                                                     |
| <b>Bain Capital / Domino's Pizza</b><br>1998                                             | ~\$1bn                 | Bain Capital — tax counsel on the buyout                      | Included for perspective. Roughly 90% of the company bought from its founder. This is what a "large" deal looked like when the relationship was already fourteen years old.                                                                                                     |

### THE PATTERN TO NOTICE

Ropes appears on these deals in three different capacities — **lead sponsor counsel** (Kioxia, Nord Anglia), **specialist regulatory counsel on someone else's deal** (Hologic), and **counsel to both sponsor and portfolio company** (NFP). Most firms only have the first. The second is how the life sciences vertical wins work independently of the private equity practice, and it is worth naming if anyone asks how the firm's parts fit together.

## SECTION 07 • THE DEAL BOOK

## Healthcare and life sciences

This is the vertical that makes Ropes different from a pure private equity firm. The work runs from billion-dollar pharma acquisitions to single-asset licensing deals, and the common thread is that the value turns on regulatory judgement rather than deal mechanics.

| MATTER                                           | VALUE          | CLIENT                     | WHY THE SECTOR KNOWLEDGE MATTERED                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|--------------------------------------------------|----------------|----------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Hologic take-private</b><br>Oct 2025          | \$18.3bn       | Blackstone and TPG         | Medical devices sit under FDA oversight. Diligence on a device portfolio is a regulatory exercise, not an accounting one – which is why sponsors hired a separate healthcare and FDA counsel for it.              |
| <b>Chiesi / KalVista Pharmaceuticals</b>         | ~\$1.9bn       | Chiesi Farmaceutici S.p.A. | An Italian pharmaceutical group buying a US-listed biotech. Note the client: a corporate, not a sponsor. The life sciences practice sells to strategics too.                                                      |
| <b>Gilgamesh Pharmaceuticals / AbbVie</b>        | up to \$1.2bn  | Gilgamesh Pharmaceuticals  | A <b>single-asset sale</b> – one clinical programme in major depressive disorder, sold rather than the company. Structuring a deal where most of the price is milestone-contingent is a life sciences speciality. |
| <b>Select Medical take-private</b><br>March 2026 | \$3.9bn        | Welsh Carson consortium    | Healthcare services, where reimbursement policy is the main driver of value. Also a sector under close antitrust and state regulatory scrutiny in the US.                                                         |
| <b>Smarter Technologies platform</b>             | part of \$18bn | New Mountain Capital       | Healthcare revenue-cycle management built by combining businesses. Buy-and-build in a regulated sector needs the regulatory team on every bolt-on.                                                                |

### THE STRUCTURAL POINT WORTH MAKING AT THE EVENT

Ask why a private equity firm needs a life sciences practice at all, and the answer is underwriting. A generalist can model a healthcare business; only a specialist can tell a sponsor whether a patent cliff, a reimbursement change or an FDA pathway makes the model worthless. **The sector knowledge is not a cross-selling opportunity – it is what lets the client bid with confidence.** That is the same argument a specialist asset manager makes about its own edge, which is why it is a good thing for you to raise.

### A CAUTION ON THE GILGAMESH DEAL

"Up to \$1.2bn" means upfront payment plus milestones that may never be paid. If you mention it, say *"up to"* – biotech deal values are routinely quoted at their maximum and rarely reached. Knowing that distinction is itself a small signal of literacy.

## SECTION 08 • THE DEAL BOOK

## Funds, secondaries and asset management M&A

The least visible third of the firm's work and the most relevant to you. None of it is a takeover you would read about in a newspaper; all of it is the plumbing of the asset management industry.

| MATTER                                                                         | VALUE                        | CLIENT                                                            | WHAT KIND OF WORK THIS IS                                                                                                                                                                                |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>EQT acquires Collier Capital</b><br>Announced 22 Jan 2026 · closing Q3 2026 | \$3.2bn<br>+ \$500m earn-out | EQT, with Vinge<br>Kirkland acted for Collier                     | <b>Asset management M&amp;A.</b> A manager buying a manager. Collier runs ~\$49bn and becomes "Collier EQT" with Jeremy Collier still leading it. The largest secondaries manager acquisition on record. |
| <b>Wireless Logic continuation vehicle</b>                                     | €2bn                         | Partners Group, as co-lead investor<br>vehicle managed by Montagu | <b>A single-asset continuation vehicle</b> for a UK-headquartered business – the sponsor moves one asset into a new fund rather than selling it. This is the modern exit, and it is a London mandate.    |
| <b>Secondaries programme</b><br>Calendar year 2025                             | 600+ deals                   | Buy-side and sell-side;<br>10 of the top 15 global buyers         | <b>Volume, not headlines.</b> LP portfolio sales, GP-leds, continuation funds, GP stakes. Ranked #1 in Secondaries Investor's law firm survey.                                                           |
| <b>PIMCO closed-end fund platform</b>                                          | 22 funds                     | PIMCO                                                             | <b>Registered fund counsel.</b> Plus four interval funds and five open-end funds. Recurring governance and regulatory work with no deal cycle attached.                                                  |
| <b>Jackson National interval funds</b>                                         | 2 funds                      | Jackson National Life Funds                                       | <b>The convergence in practice.</b> Multi-asset 1940 Act interval funds – real assets and credit opportunities in a semi-liquid registered wrapper. Exactly the product on page 13.                      |
| <b>Registered fund mandate base</b>                                            | 2,000+                       | Funds, or their independent trustees                              | Not a deal – a standing book of business. Independent trustee representation is a distinct role: advising the board that polices the manager's fees.                                                     |

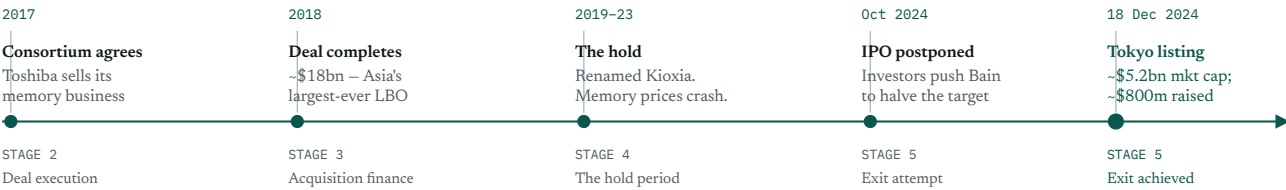
### And what London itself has been doing

|                                                                                                                                                                            |                                                                                                                                                                                                |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>TPG RISE FUND</b><br>Acquisition of Outcomes First Group, a UK specialist education provider, from Stirling Square. Sponsor-to-sponsor, cross-border, regulated sector. | <b>NAMED LONDON PE CLIENTS</b><br>Trainees report working on transactions for <b>AEA</b> , <b>Inflexion</b> and <b>Oakley Capital</b> – mid-market European sponsors, not only the mega-funds. |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|

SECTION 09 · THE DEAL TO UNDERSTAND

# One asset, six years, the entire fee cycle

Page 5 argued that Ropes' business model is a fee annuity that runs across the life of an asset. Kioxia is that argument as a single, documented example — and it is the best story in the firm's deal book precisely because it was *difficult*.



**Ropes & Gray advised Bain Capital at both ends — the 2018 buyout and the 2024 IPO.**

Six years, a global chip-market collapse, a postponed listing and a halved valuation target in between. A firm that is retained through *that* is not being retained on the strength of a pitch.

TOKYO-LED TEAM · AWARDED JAPAN DEAL OF THE YEAR AND M&A DEAL OF THE YEAR, ALB 2018

**Read the two valuations carefully.** The ~\$18bn in 2018 was the enterprise value of the whole business bought through a complex consortium; the ~\$5.2bn in 2024 was the equity market capitalisation of the listed company on day one, after Bain and Toshiba sold down only part of their holdings. They are not the same measure and comparing them directly would be wrong — a distinction worth getting right if the deal comes up.

## Four things this one deal teaches

### CONSORTIUM MECHANICS

Bain *led* a consortium rather than buying alone, and Toshiba retained an interest. Someone has to paper the relationships between the buyers themselves — governance, exit rights, deadlock. That is a whole workstream invisible from the headline number.

### WHY THE HOLD RAN LONG

Memory chips are brutally cyclical. Prices collapsed during the hold, and the exit route was dictated by market conditions rather than preference. Sponsors do not choose when to sell; the market chooses for them.

### THE FAILED ATTEMPT STILL COUNTED

An IPO was prepared and postponed in October 2024 before the December listing. Preparing a listing that does not happen is expensive, fully billed, and then largely repeated. Stage 5 is not one event.

### THE ASIA PLATFORM IS NOT DECORATIVE

The team was led from Tokyo, not New York. If anyone asks why a Boston firm has offices in Tokyo, Shanghai, Seoul, Hong Kong and Singapore, this is the answer: its clients buy Asian assets.

### HOW TO USE THIS

If someone asks what interests you about the firm's work, this is a better answer than naming the biggest deal. *"They advised Bain on the Toshiba Memory buyout in 2018 and were still there for the Kioxia IPO six years later, through a chip-market crash and a postponed listing. That's the whole business model in one asset."* It shows you understand that the fee cycle is the product, and it is a story rather than a statistic.

## SECTION 10 • THE ORIGIN

## Where the entire strategy came from

The single most important fact about Ropes & Gray is not on its website's front page. In 1984 a Boston consulting firm spun out an investment arm called Bain Capital, and the local law firm it used was Ropes & Gray. That relationship is now over forty years old, and almost everything the firm has become grew out of it.

### 1865 A Boston institution

Founded by John Codman Ropes and John Chipman Gray – Gray being a Harvard Law professor whose treatise on the rule against perpetuities is still cited. The firm spent a century as counsel to Boston institutions: by the mid-1960s its clients included the Putnam funds and Harvard.

### 1984 Bain Capital is founded – and Ropes is there from inception

The relationship dates from the firm's founding. As US private equity grew from a cottage industry into an asset class, Ropes grew with its client rather than having to win into the market from outside.

**This is the whole answer to "why is a Boston firm a private equity powerhouse?"** It was not a strategy. It was a client that became enormous.

### 1998 Domino's Pizza

Ropes tax lawyers advised Bain on the roughly \$1bn purchase of about 90% of Domino's from its founder. A landmark deal at the time – and, by then, a fourteen-year-old relationship.

### 2018–24 Toshiba Memory to the Kioxia IPO

A ~\$18bn buyout in Tokyo, then the listing six years later. See page 11.

### 2022 Bain Capital's general counsel joins Ropes & Gray

Reported at the time as underscoring a "symbiotic" relationship between the two firms.

**And it happened twice.** EQT's general counsel joined the London office in 2026. A firm that hires two clients' general counsel is not a supplier – it is part of how those clients are staffed.

### Now Traffic in the other direction

A former head of the Ropes London office left to join Bain Capital. Careers move both ways across the line, continuously.

#### WHY THIS IS THE BEST THING YOU KNOW ABOUT THE FIRM

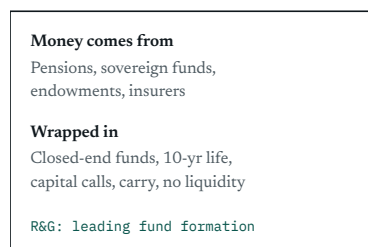
Every applicant will say Ropes is strong in private equity. Almost none will be able to say *why*. The answer is that it did not enter private equity – its client invented the industry next door to it, and the firm has been inside that relationship for forty years. That is also the honest answer to the question of whether relationships really matter in professional services: at this firm they are not a soft skill layered on top of the business, **they are the business, and the historical record proves it.**

## SECTION 11

## Standing where the industry is rebuilding itself

Most firms sit on one side of a wall. Either they do private funds – closed-end, illiquid, institutional money, ten-year lock-ups – or they do registered funds, where investors are retail and the regulation is about daily liquidity, fee levels and independent boards. Different skills, different regulators, different clients. Ropes is top-tier on **both** sides at once.

PRIVATE CAPITAL – UNREGISTERED



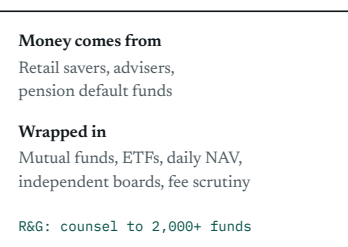
wants retail  
money

### The convergence zone

Interval funds  
Tender-offer funds  
Evergreen / semi-liquid  
Private credit BDCs  
Retail-access feeders

needs BOTH skill sets to build

REGISTERED FUNDS – '40 ACT / UCITS



wants private  
returns

a semi-liquid wrapper around illiquid  
assets still needs a way out

### Secondaries and continuation vehicles

the machinery that turns locked-up assets back into cash  
R&G #1 · 600+ deals in 2025 · 10 of the top 15 buyers

### Very few firms hold all three positions at once.

That is the argument for Ropes from an asset management seat – not that it is prestigious, but that it is standing exactly where the industry is currently rebuilding itself.

**The wall is coming down.** Private capital wants retail money because institutional allocations are near their ceiling. Retail platforms want private returns. The vehicles that join them need someone who understands both fund economics and the registered-fund rulebook – and they only function if there is a liquidity mechanism underneath.

## SECTION 12 • THE DIFFERENTIATORS

## Six things that are actually rare

Ranked by how few other firms could claim the same. Each one is a claim, the evidence for it, and why it is hard to copy.

### 01 Top-tier on both sides of the private / registered fund divide

Almost every competitor is a private funds firm *or* a registered funds firm. Ropes is both, at scale, just as the two worlds merge into evergreen and semi-liquid products.

**Evidence:** counsel to 2,000+ registered funds; simultaneously the #1-ranked secondaries practice. **Hard to copy:** you cannot lateral-hire a forty-year fund-board relationship.

### 02 Revenue that survives the deal cycle

Most elite transactional firms are a leveraged bet on M&A volume. Ropes built secondaries and restructuring alongside, so the same client list pays whichever way the cycle turns.

**Evidence:** 600+ secondaries deals in 2025; a new global restructuring chair hired with a four-partner team in 2026. **Hard to copy:** requires deliberately building capacity you hope not to use.

### 03 An information advantage over its own clients' market

The firm maintains a proprietary database of buyout fund terms. Because it papers so many funds, it sees where the market actually is on fees, hurdles, GP commitments and carry before LPs do.

**Evidence:** cited in Chambers commentary as "state-of-the-art technology". **Hard to copy:** it is a by-product of volume – you need the mandates first.

### 04 Client and firm are one talent pool

The firm hired EQT's general counsel into London as a partner. A former head of that same London office left to join Bain Capital. That traffic runs in both directions and it is unusual.

**Evidence:** Paul Dali, ex-GC of EQT, joined in 2026. **Hard to copy:** people only move like that where the relationship is already genuine.

### 05 A sector vertical deep enough to change the underwriting

Life sciences sits beside private capital because healthcare buyouts turn on things a generalist cannot price: patent cliffs, reimbursement policy, regulatory pathways.

**Evidence:** a Chambers UK 2026 Band 1 life sciences regulatory partner hired into London, July 2026. **Hard to copy:** sector credibility takes a decade.

### 06 Expansion that follows clients rather than flags

Fifteen years of London alone, then Paris and Milan inside six months – not to be a European full-service firm, but because sponsor clients were deploying there and referrals leak relationships.

**Evidence:** ten-lawyer team from Linklaters and eight-lawyer team from Latham into Paris, 2025–26. **Hard to copy:** restraint is harder than growth.

SECTION 13 • YOUR ANGLE

# It is a relationship business wearing a law firm's clothes

If you are drawn to client-facing work, this is the section that matters. Ropes' economics only work because it holds relationships rather than winning transactions – and that is a structural fact about the firm, not a line from its brochure.

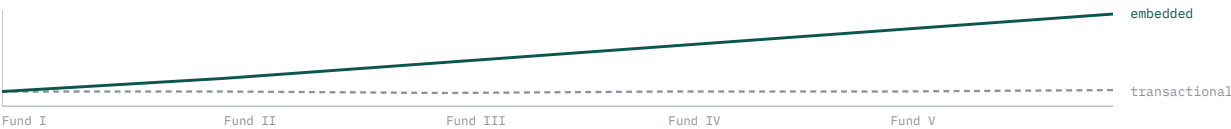
THE TRANSACTIONAL ADVISER – RE-WINS EVERY TIME



THE EMBEDDED ADVISER – THE ROPES MODEL



VALUE OF THE RELATIONSHIP OVER TIME



**The difference is what happens after the deal closes.** A transactional adviser re-enters a competition each time. An embedded adviser is already inside the next fund before it is raised. Ropes' whole cost structure – a matrix that lets five practices serve one client, offices opened where clients deploy – is built to produce the lower line, not the upper one.

## Three mechanisms that make it compound

ONE • SWITCHING COSTS

By fund III the firm holds every precedent document, the fund's own negotiated positions, and the institutional memory of what the LPs asked for last time. Changing adviser means paying someone else to relearn it.

TWO • NO INTERNAL COMPETITION

The matrix on page 4 exists so five practices can serve one client without fighting over it. That is what lets a funds partner introduce a restructuring partner rather than guarding the relationship.

THREE • USEFULNESS BETWEEN MANDATES

The buyout fund terms database means the firm has something to say when there is no live deal. Advisers who only appear when they are billing are the ones who get re-tendered.

AND THE RISK

Concentration cuts both ways. A firm this tied to private capital is exposed if sponsors stop raising funds – which is precisely why secondaries and restructuring were built up alongside. Worth raising if a partner asks what you would worry about.

## SECTION 14

## How you can prove the relationship claim

Anyone can assert that a firm is "relationship-led" – it is on every law firm website in the world. The reason you can say it about Ropes and be believed is that there are four pieces of hard evidence, and almost no applicant will have found them.

### A People move between firm and client

Ropes hired **Paul Dali**, formerly general counsel of EQT – a client – into London as a private equity partner in 2026. In the other direction, a former head of the London office left to join **Bain Capital**, another major client.

**Why it proves the point:** a general counsel only joins their outside counsel when they already know the firm from the inside. Careers do not cross that line where the relationship is purely commercial.

### B The firm opens offices where clients deploy capital

Paris and Milan launched within six months of each other in 2025 – the first continental European offices after fifteen years of London alone. Four European private equity co-heads now meet weekly, in London.

**Why it proves the point:** the alternative was referring a French deal to a French firm. Referrals leak relationships. This is a defensive move to keep a client whole, not an ambition to be a European firm.

### C It gives clients information, not just advice

The proprietary database of buyout fund terms lets the firm tell a sponsor where the market actually is on fees, hurdles and carry – before that information is public.

**Why it proves the point:** this is the classic relationship move in any advisory business. You become valuable *between* mandates by bringing something the client cannot get elsewhere.

### D Lawyers go and sit inside the client

London runs client secondments – to Liberty Global among others – plus a three-month antitrust secondment to the Dublin office. Secondments are allocated when a client asks for one.

**Why it proves the point:** a client only asks for a seconded lawyer when they already treat the firm as an extension of their own team.

#### THE SENTENCE THIS EARNS YOU

"Ropes doesn't win deals so much as win sponsors – and the proof isn't in the marketing, it's that the firm hired EQT's general counsel while a former head of its London office left for Bain Capital. Adviser and client are effectively one community." Say that and you are no longer a candidate who has read a website.

SECTION 15 • READ THIS BEFORE THE EVENT

# What "client-facing" honestly means here

One caution, because it will save you from the single most common mistake at an event like this. A trainee solicitor's first two years are **not** client-facing in the way a coverage, investor relations or sales role is. If you tell a partner you are drawn to Ropes because you want client contact from day one, they will know you have not understood the job. The relationship skill matters enormously – it just arrives on a different timetable, and it starts internally.

| SEAT             | WHAT A TRAINEE ACTUALLY DOES                                                               | CLIENT CONTACT                                                                         |
|------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Private equity   | Transaction management, tracker checklists, board minutes, portfolio company due diligence | Limited early on – the seat most trainees do, and the least client-facing at the start |
| Antitrust        | Merger control research, drafting papers, liaising with counsel across offices             | <b>Direct.</b> Trainees interact with clients and with opposing parties                |
| Asset management | Regulatory and AML advice; fund marketing and jurisdictional applications                  | <b>Advisory.</b> The team's product is answering client questions                      |
| Finance          | Checklist management, document amendments, basic drafting – "very process-heavy"           | Low; the value is learning how deals are actually built                                |
| Real estate      | PE real estate joint ventures and real estate finance                                      | Significant international exposure and responsibility                                  |

## Where relationship skill actually shows up early

This is the more interesting point, and it is well evidenced. At Ropes, **internal** relationships are the mechanism for almost everything that determines your career there.

|                                                                                                                                                                                                           |                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <p><b>SEAT ALLOCATION</b></p> <p>Informal. Trainees rank preferences in conversation with graduate recruitment. One trainee's summary: <i>"The onus is on you to reach out to people informally."</i></p> | <p><b>QUALIFICATION</b></p> <p>Typically no formal interview unless a department is oversubscribed – it happens through conversations with teams, partners and associates. The firm retained all qualifiers in 2025.</p>   |
| <p><b>SUPERVISION</b></p> <p>Trainees share an office with a supervising associate who volunteered for the role. Proximity, not process, is how the learning happens.</p>                                 | <p><b>PRO BONO</b></p> <p>A 20-hour annual target, with a family law clinic in East London. One trainee: <i>"they do trust you to run with it."</i> Often the first matter where you are the one the client speaks to.</p> |

SAY IT THIS WAY INSTEAD

Not *"I want client contact early."* Instead: **"I'm interested in the part of this job where you understand a client's business well enough to be useful before you're asked – and I know that starts with being the person in the team who is trusted with the relationship internally first."** That shows you understand the trajectory rather than romanticising it.

## SECTION 16

## What they have been doing, and why

Ropes had London for fifteen years and nothing else in Europe. Then, in roughly eighteen months, it built a continental platform. Every move has a reason.

|              |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
|--------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 2010         | <b>London opens</b><br>Ludgate Hill. The bridgehead for European private capital work, and for fifteen years the only European office.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| Jan 2025     | <b>Neill Jakobe becomes vice chair</b><br>Elected 2024 for a five-year term. Previously co-head of the global private equity practice.<br><b>Why:</b> the firm put its private equity leadership into the governance tier. Strategy is now set by people with sponsor-side instincts.                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| 2025         | <b>Paris and Milan launch within six months</b><br>The first continental offices. A ten-lawyer private funds and tax team arrived from Linklaters; an eight-lawyer M&A and private equity team from Latham & Watkins.<br><b>Why:</b> follow the client, not the flag. Referring a French or Italian deal to a local firm leaks the relationship. Defensive as much as expansionary.                                                                                                       |
| 2025–26      | <b>Cataldo Piccarreta joins as co-head of European PE transactions</b><br>From Latham. Four co-heads now run European private equity and meet weekly — in London.<br><b>Why:</b> London is being run as the hub of one European platform, with Paris, Milan and Dublin as spokes, rather than four independent offices.                                                                                                                                                                   |
| 2026         | <b>Paul Dali joins London from EQT</b><br>Formerly general counsel of EQT — a client — now a private equity partner.<br><b>Why:</b> hiring a sponsor's own GC says how close the relationship is. Traffic runs both ways: a former head of the London office left for Bain Capital.                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| Jan 2026     | <b>EQT / Collier Capital</b><br>\$3.2bn plus a \$500m earn-out; the largest secondaries manager acquisition on record. Ropes advised EQT with Vinge.<br><b>Why it is the deal to know:</b> the European platform, the secondaries franchise and asset management M&A producing one mandate at once. Private Capital Team of the Year, June 2026.                                                                                                                                          |
| Jun–Sep 2026 | <b>Continued hiring into the strategy</b><br>Peter Rosen into New York for global secondaries. Alison Dennis, Chambers UK 2026 Band 1 for life sciences regulatory, into London in July. A new global restructuring chair with a four-partner New York team. A new firm general counsel in September.<br><b>Why restructuring matters:</b> it is the hedge. If leveraged portfolio companies come under pressure, the same client list generates restructuring fees instead of deal fees. |

## THE STRATEGY IN ONE SENTENCE

16 Ropes is not trying to become a European full-service firm. It is building a **narrow, deep private capital platform** across London, Paris, Milan and Dublin so a sponsor client never has to instruct anyone else — and adding secondaries and restructuring so the revenue survives whichever way the cycle turns.

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## SECTION 17

## Two drafted answers

Q. Why does Ropes & Gray appeal to you and what do you hope to gain from attending this masterclass? (150–200 words)

VERSION B — RELATIONSHIP-LED • RECOMMENDED

173 words

Ropes & Gray appeals to me because of how it makes money. It doesn't win deals so much as win sponsors, and then earns from one relationship for a decade — raising the fund, doing the buyout, financing it, holding it, and building the exit. That model only works if the relationships are genuinely deep, and the evidence is that they are: the firm hired EQT's general counsel into its London office, and a former head of that office left to join Bain Capital. Adviser and client are effectively one community.

That is the part of professional services I want to work in. I am drawn to the client-facing side — being the person who understands a client's business well enough to be useful before being asked — and Ropes is unusual in that its strategy is built on exactly that, rather than on scale.

From the masterclass I want to hear from trainees how early that client contact really begins, which seats offer it, and to get honest feedback on my application before the deadline.

VERSION A — ASSET-MANAGEMENT-LED

176 words

Ropes & Gray appeals to me because it chose depth over breadth. Rather than covering everything, it built around private capital and life sciences, and that focus shows in the work.

What interests me most, coming from an asset management angle, is that the firm sits on both sides of a line most firms only cross once. It is regular counsel to more than 2,000 registered funds or their independent trustees, while running the market's leading secondaries practice, advising ten of the fifteen largest global buyers. Those two worlds are converging through evergreen and interval structures, and Ropes is already positioned where that happens. Advising EQT on its acquisition of Collier Capital is the clearest example: a sponsor buying a secondaries manager because liquidity, not origination, is now the binding constraint in private markets.

From the masterclass I want to test that reading against people who do the work — to hear from trainees how the funds, transactional and regulatory teams genuinely share one sponsor client, and to get direct feedback on my application before I submit.

### WHICH TO SEND, AND WHAT TO CHECK

**Send Version B.** It answers "why us" with something about the firm's actual business model rather than its reputation, it carries evidence nobody else will have, and it matches the career interest you actually have. You have roughly **27 words of headroom** — the best use is one sentence in paragraph two naming something you have genuinely done that involved holding a relationship.

**Before submitting:** re-verify the Collier figures on the firm's newsroom if you use Version A (announced January 2026, due to close Q3 2026, so "acquiring" may need to become "acquired"), and confirm your **minimum five hours with SEO London** are logged. That is a hard eligibility gate independent of the answer.

## SECTION 18

## Questions, and how to follow up

The day runs 10:00–15:30 and includes a trainee Q&A, an application workshop, a diversity panel and a negotiation exercise. These four questions are answerable, non-obvious, and signal that you did the reading.

- 
- 01      Now that London, Paris and Milan run as one platform, does a trainee get staffed on European deals, or does the seat system keep you in London work?
- Tests whether the platform strategy reaches the bottom of the firm. Trainees will have a real answer.
- 
- 02      Is there a funds seat in the London rotation, and do trainees see continuation vehicle work, or does that sit mainly with the US offices?
- Shows you know the practice map, and it is genuinely useful information for you.
- 
- 03      With so much growth coming from lateral partner hires rather than internal promotion, how does that change what it's like to be an associate here?
- A real question about the strategy's cost. Ask it neutrally, not as a challenge.
- 
- 04      Does the firm expect the retail push into private markets to become a meaningful part of the London practice, or does that stay a US registered-funds story?
- The asset management question. Connects your interest to their business, and very few candidates will ask it.
- 

### THE NEGOTIATION EXERCISE

Worth knowing what the firm's own negotiators actually do. In a fund formation context the negotiation is GP against LP over management fees, hurdle rates, key-person clauses and side letters – not a haggle over price. If the exercise is transactional, the same instinct applies: **look for the terms that allocate risk, not just the number**. Candidates who chase price look junior; candidates who ask "who carries this if it goes wrong" look trained.

### IF RELATIONSHIPS ARE YOUR ANGLE, BEHAVE LIKE IT ON THE DAY

You are attending an event about relationship-building, so the event is itself the test. Three practical things:

**One.** Get two or three names, not ten business cards. Depth beats coverage, which is the same argument the firm makes about itself.

**Two.** Ask a trainee what they were doing last week. It is a better question than "what's the culture like", it gets a real answer, and it gives you something specific to reference later.

**Three.** Follow up within 48 hours with something useful rather than something grateful – a short note referencing the specific thing they told you. That is the actual skill being tested, and it is the one most candidates skip.

## SECTION 19 • PROVENANCE

## What is held versus what is verified

You asked what I already knew about this firm as against what I looked up. That distinction matters for you specifically, because anything in the second column below could be wrong, and a confidently misattributed fact in an interview costs more than not knowing it. The three tiers below are ordered by how safely you can use them.

### Tier 1 • Held as background and confirmed in research — safe to use

|                                                                                        |                                                                                                        |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Founded 1865 in Boston</b> by John Codman Ropes and John Chipman Gray               | Confirmed. Gray was a Harvard Law professor; his rule against perpetuities treatise remains canonical. |
| <b>Counsel to Bain Capital since its 1984 inception</b>                                | Confirmed, and described in the trade press as a "symbiotic" relationship.                             |
| <b>Boston institutional client base</b> — Putnam funds, Harvard                        | Confirmed as clients by the mid-1960s. This is the origin of the registered funds practice.            |
| <b>Toshiba Memory buyout was ~\$18bn</b> and Asia's largest LBO at the time            | Confirmed, including the Tokyo-led team and the 2018 awards.                                           |
| <b>Peer set is Kirkland, Latham, Simpson Thacher, Debevoise</b> — not the Magic Circle | Consistent with rankings and the firm's own positioning.                                               |

### Tier 2 • Held as background, not confirmed here — use as context, never as a quoted fact

|                                                                                                                           |                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>A historic Fidelity Investments relationship</b>                                                                       | Widely associated with the firm, but I could <b>not</b> confirm it. Putnam is the one that is documented. Do not name Fidelity.                                                  |
| <b>The healthcare vertical grew from Boston teaching hospitals</b>                                                        | Plausible and consistent with the firm's Boston history, but not directly evidenced in what I found. Say "grew out of its Boston institutional base" instead.                    |
| <b>Embeddedness in the wider Boston buyout cluster</b> — Thomas H. Lee, Berkshire Partners, Advent, Summit, TA Associates | Reasonable inference from geography and market position; individual relationships not verified. Treat as background colour only.                                                 |
| <b>A more collegial culture than Kirkland</b>                                                                             | A common market perception, not a fact. Trainee accounts do describe strong support and no fear about raising workload — but hours reportedly range from a 5:30pm finish to 2am. |

### Tier 3 • Things that turned out to be wrong or unsupported

|                                                                        |                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Any practice-level revenue split</b>                                | Not published by the firm. Figures circulating online such as "45% private equity, 25% life sciences" are not sourced to Ropes. Do not use them.                                                         |
| <b>A single reliable trainee pay and retention figure</b>              | Sources disagree — £62k/£67k and NQ £170k in one place, £60k/£65k and NQ £165k in another; retention reported as 75% in one and as all qualifiers retained in 2025 in another. Quote a range or nothing. |
| <b>Comparing Kioxia's \$18bn purchase to its \$5.2bn IPO valuation</b> | Different measures — enterprise value of the whole business versus day-one equity market capitalisation of the listco. The comparison is invalid.                                                        |

## SECTION 20

## Sources and caveats

### READ THIS BEFORE QUOTING ANYTHING

Everything here is compiled from public reporting as at **10 September 2026**. Three specific cautions:

**1. No practice-level revenue split exists.** Ropes publishes revenue and profit per equity partner and nothing more. The Panel B bars on page 6 are inferred and deliberately drawn without an axis. Do not quote a percentage.

**2. Trainee pay and retention figures differ between sources and cohorts.** Legal Cheek's current profile gives £62,000 and £67,000 for the two trainee years with an NQ rate of £170,000; the Chambers Student guide reports £60,000, £65,000 and £165,000 from an earlier cycle. Retention is reported at 75% in one place and as all qualifiers retained in 2025 in another. Quote a range, or don't quote it.

**3. The EQT / Collier deal was still closing.** Announced 22 January 2026 at \$3.2bn plus up to \$500m earn-out, expected to close Q3 2026. Check the tense before you write about it.

### Where each thing came from

| SOURCE                                        | USED FOR                                                                                                 |
|-----------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Legal Cheek</b> – firm profile             | FY2025 revenue, PEP, revenue per lawyer, headcount, offices, London trainee numbers and salaries         |
| <b>Legal Business</b> – European PE expansion | Paris and Milan launches, the four European PE co-heads, London as hub                                   |
| <b>The Global Legal Post</b>                  | Latham and Linklaters Paris team hires; the London head's move to Bain Capital                           |
| <b>Law360</b> and <b>EQT</b> press release    | Collier Capital deal value, structure, earn-out, AUM, timetable and advisers                             |
| <b>Ropes &amp; Gray</b> newsroom              | Alison Dennis and Peter Rosen hires, The Lawyer award, the firm's own market commentary                  |
| <b>Chambers and Legal 500</b>                 | Practice rankings, the buyout fund terms database, registered funds client detail, PIMCO mandate         |
| <b>Secondaries Investor</b>                   | #1 ranking, 600+ 2025 transactions, 10 of the top 15 buyers                                              |
| <b>Chambers Student</b> – True Picture        | Seat structure, what trainees do by seat, client contact, secondments, seat allocation and qualification |

Prepared for the Ropes & Gray Masterclass application, SEO London, deadline Thursday 17 September 2026 at 12:00. Point of contact: corporatelaw@seo-london.org. This document is a research aid – the judgements in it are arguments to test at the event, not facts to recite.